



The Open Sesame of Business

The recently held seminar on open source at the Bangalore International Exhibition Centre was an attempt at creating awareness on using open source for business enterprises. The seminar covered the challenges companies face while making an 'open' shift, and the ways to tackle them. It was jointly organised by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) and the Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises, government of India.

Lack of awareness prevents enterprises from enjoying the benefits of open source applications. This was one of the conclusions of a seminar on open source software and SMEs, held in the last week of February in Bangalore. "Open source is a great platform for industries. For instance, even the New York Stock Exchange runs on open source applications. Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) can follow open source as a developmental model as well as a business model," said Nandu Pradhan, president and managing director, Red Hat India, while delivering the keynote

address at the seminar.

According to Pradhan, companies like Red Hat take the free resources from the open source community; develop, integrate and test them; and then make them ready for enterprises. "We provide the support. Unlike proprietary software, which sells the product, open source products are free, and services are charged," he said.

In his special address, M. Sasikumar, associate director (research), C-DAC, stressed on the freedom that open source software delivers. He said that lack of awareness was the main barrier to SMEs opting for FOSS. "In large scale sectors,